Ershova 2021: *Wh*-agreement in West Circassian relative clauses

Syntax 3
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1 Overview

MAIN CLAIM: Multiple *wh*-agreement constructions in West Circassian can be interpreted as expressions of parasitic gap dependencies. The additional *wh*-agreement is restricted by the same constraints that apply to parasitic gaps.

The patterns of multiple *wh*-agreement offer a diagnostic for identifying the syntactic structure of clauses: the absolutive DP occupies a position that c-commands all other verbal arguments.

- RC with multiple *wh*-Agree contains a licensing trace (primary agreement) and a parasitic gap.
- The trace triggering the primary *wh*-Agree may license a parasitic gap that triggers an additional *wh*-Agree.
- **Anti-C-Command Condition** (Engdahl 1983:22): "A parasitic gap may not be c-commanded by the real (licensing) gap."
- Ershova (2022): In English, objects do not c-command adjuncts → can license parasitic gap.

  (1) Which article$_i$ did John [file t_i] [without reading __$_{PG}$]?

  Subjects c-command adjuncts → cannot license parasitic gap.

  (2) *Which article [t_i got filed by John [without him reading __$_{PG}$]]?

→ **Prediction of a high absolutive syntax in West Circassian:** A trace from an absolutive position cannot license parasitic gaps in lower positions (ERG and IO)

2 Background on West Circassian

- West Circassian: a polysynthetic language with head-marking and pro-drop.
- Head marking on verbal forms: | ABS- | IO- + APPL- | ERG-

(3)

sə-	qə-	p-	f-	a-	r-	jə-	ʁe-	λeʁʷə	-ʁ
1SG.ABS-	DIR-	2SG.IO-	BEN-	3PL.IO-	DAT-	3SG.ERG-	CAUS-	see	-PST

'He showed me to them for your sake.'
(Korotkova and Lander 2010:301)

- Head marking on nominals: inalienable vs. alienable possessive marker

  (4) a. Inalienable

  s-šəpχʷə-xe-r
  1SG.PR-sister-PL-ABS
  'my sisters'

  b. Alienable

  t-jə-ʁʷəneʁʷə-xe-m
  1PL.PR-POSS-neighbor-PL-OBL
  'our neighbors'

- **Case marking** displays ergative alignment: absolutive *-r*, oblique/ergative *-m*

  (5) a. Intransitive subjects *-r*

  č'ale-**r** Ø-q-e-ŝe
  boy-**ABS** 3ABS-DIR-DYN-dance
  'The boy is dancing.'

  b. Direct objects *-r* & Transitive subjects *-m*

  ẑʷaḳʷe-**m** qʷəbʁʷe-**r** Ø-ə-ẑʷa-ʁ
  plowman-**OBL** field-**ABS** 3ABS-3SG.ERG-plow-PST
  'The plowman plowed the field.'

  c. Applied objects *-m*

  λə-r ŝʷəzə-**m** Ø-[Ø-d]-eʔepəʔe
  man-ABS woman-**OBL** 3SG.ABS-[3SG.IO-COM]-help.DYN
  'The husband is helping the wife.'
  (Arkadiev et al. 2009:53)

  d. Possessor *-m*

  ŝʷəzə-**m** ə-qʷe
  woman-**OBL** 3SG.PR-son
  'the woman's son'

  e. Complements of postpositions *-m*

  mə ŝʷəzə-**m** paje
  this woman-**OBL** for
  'for this woman'

- Appl^0 and v^0 assign inherent case to their specifiers, oblique (IO) and ergative (TrS), respectively. T^0 assigns absolutive case to both IntrS and DO.

Caponigro and Polinsky (2011) claim a distinction of absolutive case between the two structural sources, T^0 for IntrS and v^0 for DO. How does Ershova's analysis account for a uniform absolutive case assignment (by T^0)?

- **Relative clauses (RCs)** involves the movement of a relative operator to Spec,CP.

(6) General structure of a West Circassian RC
[$_{CP}$ Op$_i$ C[wh] [$_{TP}$…t$_i$…]]

- Relativization of a non-absolutive DP involves the prefix *zə-*

(7) Ergative subject

a. Finite clause

mə ḉ'ale-m(ERG) ə-š velosjəped
this boy-OBL 3SG.PR-brother bicycle
Ø- Ø- r- **jə-** tə -ʁ
3ABS- 3SG.IO- DAT- **3SG.ERG-** give -PST
'This boy gave a bicycle to his brother.'

b. Relative clause

marə [**ḉ'al-ew$_i$** t_i(ERG) ə-š velosjəped
here **boy-ADV** 3SG.PR-brother bicycle
Ø- Ø- je- **zə-** tə -ʁe] -r
3ABS- 3SG.IO- DAT- **WH.ERG-** give -PST -ABS
'Here is the boy that gave a bicycle to his brother.'

(8) Applied object

a. **mə ḉ'ele-ç̣əḳ^{w}ə-m** Ø-jane Ø- Ø- fe- g^{w}əbž -zepət
this boy-small-OBL 3SG.PR-mother 3ABS- **3SG.IO-** BEN- angry -always
'His mother is always angry at this boy.'

b. marə [**ḉ'ele-ç̣əḳ^w-ew$_i$** t_i(IO) Ø-jane
here **boy-small-ADV** 3SG.PR-mother
Ø- **zə-** fe- g^{w}əbž -zepətə -re] -r
3ABS- **WH.IO-** BEN- angry -always -DYN -ABS
'Here is the boy at whom his mother is always angry.'

(9) Possessor

marə ŝ^{w}əz-ew [$_{RC}$ *Op$_i$* [$_{DP}$ t_i(PR) **z-jə-pŝaŝe**] dax-ew
here woman-ADV **WH.PR-POSS-girl** good-ADV
Ø-qa-ŝ^{w}e-re] -r
3ABS-DIR-dance-PRES -ABS
'Here is the woman whose daughter dances well.'

- Relativization of an absolutive DP: no overt relativizing morpheme

(10)

a. **ha-r** Ø-jə-xozjajən Ø- Ø- je- ceqa -ʁ
dog-ABS 3SG.PR-POSS-owner **3ABS-** 3SG.IO- DAT- bite -PST
'The dog bit its owner.'

b. se sə-Ø-š'e-š'əne [**ha-w$_i$** t_i(ABS) Ø-jə-xozjajən
I 1SG.ABS-3SG.IO-LOC-fear **dog-ADV** 3SG.PR-owner
Ø- Ø- je- ceqa -ʁe] -m
WH.ABS- 3SG.IO- DAT- bite -PST -OBL
'I fear the dog that bit its owner.'

- Three types of RC constructions w.r.t. nominal head:

i. RC containing the N head on the left edge (internally headed) (as seen above)

ii. RC preceding the nominal head (externally headed)

(11) [$_{RC}$ Op$_i$ t_i(ERG) Ø-jə-ŝhanʁ^{w}ənče Ø- xe- **zə-** wətə -ʁe] **ḉ'ale-r** marə
3SG.PR-POSS-window 3ABS- LOC- **WH.ERG-** break -PST **boy-ABS** here
'Here is the boy that broke his window.'

iii. Headless RC

(12) [$_{RC}$ Op$_i$ asλan t_i(IO) Ø- **zə-** fae -zepətə] -m ə-š-xe-r
Aslan 3ABS- **WH.IO-** want -always -OBL 3SG.PR-brother-PL-ABS
Ø-Ø-faj-ep
3ABS-3SG.IO-want-NEG
'[What Aslan always wants] his brothers don't want.'

- Spell-out rules for *wh*-agreement:

(13) a. Impoverishment rule: [Φ] → Ø / [___;WH;AGR]
b. Oblique case *wh*-agreement: [WH;OBL;AGR] → /zə-/
c. Elsewhere case: [AGR] → /Ø-/

- **Multiple *wh*-agreement:**

(14) Intraclausal RC

a. marə [$_{RC}$ č̣'al-ew$_i$ [$_{DP}$ *pro*$_{i/j}$(PR) **ə**-š](ERG) t_i(IO) velosjəped
here boy-ADV **3SG.PR**-brother bicycle
Ø- qə- **ze-** r- jə- tə -ʁe] -r
3ABS- DIR- **WH.IO-** DAT- 3SG.ERG- give -PST -ABS
'Here is the boy$_i$ to whom his$_{i/j}$ brother gave a bicycle.'

b. marə [$_{RC}$ č̣'al-ew$_i$ [$_{DP}$ *pro*$_{i/*j}$(PR) **zə**-š](ERG) t_i(IO) velosjəped
here boy-ADV **WH.PR**-brother bicycle
Ø- qə- **ze-** r- jə- tə -ʁe] -r
3ABS- DIR- **WH.IO-** DAT- 3SG.ERG- give -PST -ABS
'Here is the boy$_i$ to whom his$_{i/*j}$ brother gave a bicycle.'

(15) Cross-clausal RC

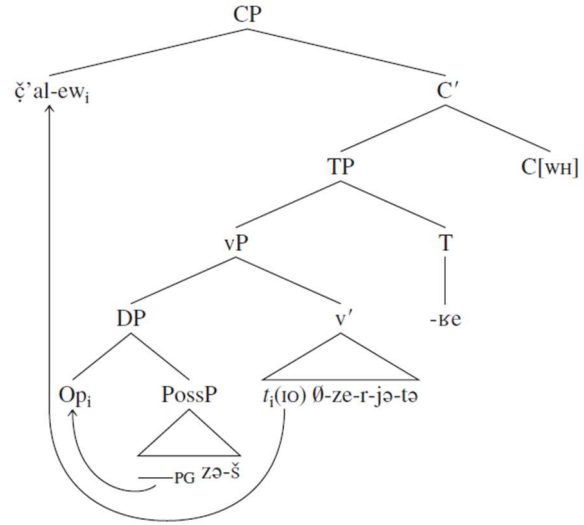
a. mə č̣'ale-m$_i$(ERG) varenje Ø- j- e- šxə [$_{CP}$ *pro*$_i$(ERG) swəpə-r
this boy-OBL jam 3ABS- 3SG.ERG- DYN- eat soup-ABS
Ø- ə- mə- wəx -ze]
3ABS- 3SG.ERG- NEG- finish -CVB
'This boy is eating jam without finishing the soup.'

b. marə [$_{RC}$ č̣'al-ew$_i$ t_i(ERG) varenje Ø- **zə-** šxə -re -r [$_{CP}$ *pro*$_i$(ERG)
here boy-ADV jam 3ABS- **WH.ERG-** eat -DYN -ABS
s^{w}əpə-r Ø- **ə/zə-** mə- wəx -ze]]
soup-ABS 3ABS- **3SG/WH.ERG-** NEG- finish -CVB
'Here is the boy who is eating jam without finishing the soup.'

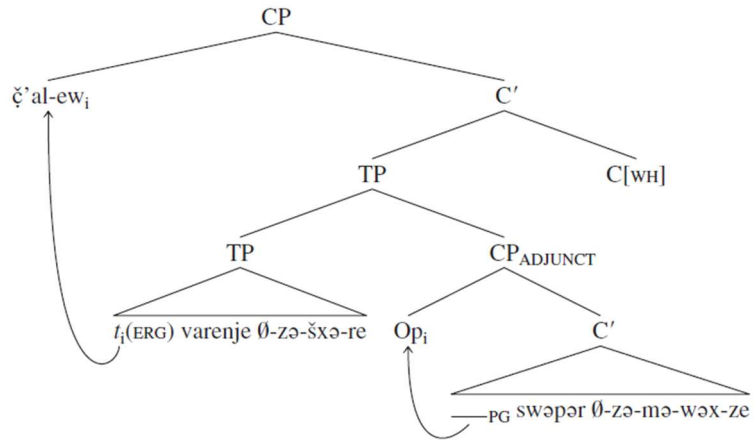
3 The evidence: Parasitic gaps

MAIN POINT: The behaviour of the additional *wh*-agreement marker are governed by similar syntactic rules and contraints applied to parasitic gaps.

(16) Structure for multiple *wh*-agreement in (14b)



(17) Structure for multiple *wh*-agreement in (15b)



- Additional *wh*-agreement can freely alternate with pronouns (in certain contexts), paralleling parasitic gap dependency with coreferencing.

3.1. Dependency: Islands vs Non-islands

MAIN POINT: The additional *wh*-agreement cannot appear unless the primary one is present.

- **The applied and ergative DPs are islands for extraction**, so subextraction from them is banned.

→ Recursive relativization as a repair strategy (different from a parasitic gap dependency)

(18) Possessor of an applied object (IO)

a. [DP [**mwe ŝʷəzə-m**](PR) **ə**-qʷe](IO) ç̌'elejeʁaǯe-r Ø- **Ø-** je- çeça -ʁ
this woman-OBL **3SG.PR**-son teacher-ABS 3ABS- **3SG.IO**- DAT- scold -PST
'The teacher scolded this woman's son.'

b. *mwarə [RC ŝʷəz-ewi [DP ti(PR) **zə**-qʷe](IO) ç̌'elejeʁaǯe-r
here woman-ADV **WH.PR**-son teacher-ABS
Ø- **Ø-** je- çeça -ʁe] -r
3ABS- **3SG.IO**- DAT- scold -PST -ABS
Intended: 'Here is the woman whose son the teacher scolded.'

c. mwarə [RC ŝʷəz-ewi [DP ti(PR) **zə**-qʷe]j(ABS) [RC Opj ç̌'elejeʁaǯe-r tj(IO)
here woman-ADV **WH.PR**-son teacher-ABS
Ø- **z-** e- çeça -ʁe]] -r
3ABS- **WH.IO**- DAT- scold -PST -ABS
'Here is the woman whose son the teacher scolded.' (Lit. 'Here is the woman whose son is the one the teacher scolded.')

(19) Possessor of an ergative subject

a. *mwarə [RC ŝʷəz-ewi [DP ti(PR) **z**-jə-λ̣](ERG) wəne-xe-r
here woman-ADV **WH.PR**-POSS-man house-PL-ABS
Ø- **ə-** ŝə -re] -r
3ABS- **3SG.ERG**- do -DYN -ABS
Intended: 'Here is the woman whose husband builds houses.'

b. mwarə [RC ŝʷəz-ewi [DP ti(PR) **z**-jə-λ̣]j(ABS) [RC Opj tj(ERG) wəne-xe-r
here woman-ADV **WH.PR**-POSS-man house-PL-ABS
Ø- **zə-** ŝə -re]] -r
3ABS- **WH.ERG**- do -DYN -ABS
'Here is the woman whose husband builds houses.' (Lit. 'Here is the woman whose husband is the one that builds houses.')

- Another strategy: introducing a parasitic gap to trigger an additional wh-agreement.

(20) Multiple *wh*-agreement

[RC Opi [DP *pro*i/___PG(PR) **ə/zə**-š](IO) ti(ERG) konfet
3SG/WH.PR-brother candy
Ø- Ø- je- **zə-** tə -ʁe] pŝaŝe-m sə-Ø-š'ə-tχʷə-ʁ
3ABS- 3SG.IO- DAT- **WH.ERG**- give -PST girl-OBL 1SG.ABS-3SG.IO-LOC-praise-PST
'I praised the girli that gave candy to heri brother.'

- Case-marking in the matrix pseudocleft vs. multiple *wh*-agreement

(21) Matrix pseudocleft

s-qʷe-xe-**r** arə [RC Opi ti(ERG) zeç̌'e laʁe-xe-r
1SG.PR-SON-PL-ABS PRED all dish-PL-ABS
Ø- zə- qʷəta -ʁe] -xe -r
3ABS- WH.ERG- break -PST -PL -ABS
'My sons are the ones who broke all the dishes.'

(22) Conflict of case marking in multiple *wh*-agreement constructions

marə [RC ŝʷəz-ewi [DP ti **z**-jə-ç̌'ale / ??**z**-jə-ç̌'ale-xe-**r** /
here woman-ADV **WH.PR**-POSS-boy / ??**WH.PR**-POSS-boy-PL-ABS /
??**z**-jə-ç̌'ale-xe-**m**] [RC Opi ti(ERG) dax-ew wered
??**WH.PR**-POSS-boy-PL-OBL pretty-ADV song
Ø- qe- **zə-** ʔʷe -re]] -r
3ABS- DIR- **WH.ERG**- say -DYN -ABS
'Here is the woman whose children sing well.'

- **Adjuncts are also islands for extraction**: elements from an adjunct cannot be directly relativized.

(23) Adjunct clauses

xet-a [RC Opj asλani mafe-m rjene [CP *pro*i(ABS) ***pro*j(IO)**/___PG
who-Q Aslan day-OBL whole
Ø- **Ø-je-** / **z-e-** mə- w -ew] ***t*j(IO)**
3ABS- **3SG.IO-DAT**- / **WH.IO-DAT**- NEG- hit -ADV
Ø- **zə-** de- ǯegʷə -re] -r
3ABS- **WH.IO**- COM- play -DYN -ABS
'Who does Aslan play with ___ all day without hitting them / ___?'

*xet-a [RC Opj asλani mafe-m rjene [CP *pro*i(ABS) ***t*j(IO)**
who-Q Aslan day-OBL whole
Ø- **z-** e- mə- w -ew] Ø- (Ø- de)- ǯegʷə -re] -r
3ABS- **WH.IO**- DAT- NEG- hit -ADV 3ABS- 3SG.IO- COM- play -DYN -ABS
Intended: 'Who does Aslan play (with him/her) all day without hitting ___?'

Relativization of coreferential arguments:

- **Nonfactual clausal complements are non-islands**, so direct extraction of an argument from within an embedded clause is allowed.
However, relativization of that argument when it is coreferential with one of the arguments of the matrix verb is prohibited.

(24)

a. xet-a [$_{RC}$ Op$_i$ t_i(IO) Ø- **z-** jə- ç̣'ase -r [$_{CP}$ *pro*$_i$/___$_{PG}$(IO)
who-Q 3ABS- **WH.IO-** LOC- like -ABS
podarke-xe-r Ø- **Ø/ze-** r- a- tə -n -ew]]
gift-PL-ABS 3ABS- **3SG/WH.IO-** DAT- 3PL.ERG- give -MOD -ADV
'Who likes to be given gifts?' (Lit. 'Who likes for them to give gifts to him/her?')

b. *xet-a [$_{RC}$ Op$_i$ *pro*$_i$(IO) Ø- **Ø-** jə- ç̣'ase -r [$_{CP}$ t_i(IO) podarke-xe-r
who-Q 3ABS- **3SG.IO-** LOC- like -ABS gift-PL-ABS
Ø- **ze-** r- a- tə -n -ew]]
3ABS- **WH.IO-** DAT- 3PL.ERG- give -MOD -ADV
Intended: 'Who likes to be given gifts?'

- **Absolutive DPs are non-islands**, so a possessor of an absolutive DP can be directly relativized, but not in the presence of a coreferential verbal participant.

(25)

*[$_{RC}$ Op$_i$ [$_{DP}$ t_i **zə-**š](ABS) ***pro***$_i$(IO) Ø- q- **Ø-** je- wa -ʁe] ç̣'ale-m
WH.PR-brother 3ABS- DIR- **3SG.IO-** DAT- hit -PST boy-OBL
s-Ø-je-wəŝəjə-š'ta-ʁ
1SG.ABS-3SG.IO-DAT-console-IPF-PST
Intended: 'I consoled the boy whose$_i$ brother hit him$_i$.'

3.2. Island sensitivity

MAIN POINT: The additional wh-agreement can be licensed within certain syntactic islands, but it cannot be licensed if it is embedded within another island (i.e., crossing more than one island boundary is bad).

(26) Who did John visit __$_{LG}$
a. *Nonisland*: [without claiming [that he knew __$_{PG}$]]
b. *Adjunct island*: ??[after offending me [by not introducing me to __$_{PG}$]]

(27)

a. marə [$_{RC}$ bzəλfəʁ-ew$_i$ [$_{ADJUNCT}$ [$_{COMP}$ *pro*$_i$/**?**___$_{PG}$(IO)
here woman-ADV
sə- **Ø/?z-** de- g^{w}əš'əʔe -nə -m] sə-pəλə-fe] zə-g^{w}ere
1SG.ABS- **3SG/?WH.IO-** COM- speak -MOD -OBL 1SG.ABS-attempt-LIM one-INDEF
t_i(IO) Ø- qə- **z-** fə- tje- wa -ʁe] -r
3ABS- DIR- **WH.IO-** BEN- LOC- hit -PST -ABS
'Here is the woman whom someone called [while I was trying [to speak with her]].'

b. marə [$_{RC}$ ŝ^{w}əz-ew$_i$ [$_{ADJUNCT}$ [$_{ADJUNCT}$ *pro*$_i$/**??**___$_{PG}$(IO)
here woman-ADV
sə- **Ø/??z-** de- g^{w}əš'əʔ -ew] sə- š'e- sə -fe] zə-g^{w}ere
1SG.ABS- **3SG/??WH.IO-** COM- speak -ADV 1SG.ABS- LOC- sit -LIM one-INDEF
t_i(IO) Ø- qə- **z-** fə- tje- wa -ʁe] -r
3ABS- DIR- **WH.IO-** BEN- LOC- hit -PST -ABS
'Here is the woman whom someone called [while I was sitting [talking to her]].'

3.3. Non-PP licensing

MAIN POINT: The additional wh-agreement cannot be licensed by a postpositional phrase (PP) trace, similar to how parasitic gaps are not licensed by PP gaps.

(28) a. This is a topic$_i$ you should think about t_i [before talking about __$_{PG}$]
b. *This is a topic about which$_i$ you should think t_i [before talking __$_{PG}$]

- A (locative) PP can be relativized and/or referred to with a null pronoun, but it cannot license a parasitic gap → no additional *wh*-agreement is allowed.

(29)

[$_{PP}$ t-jə-ʁ^{w}əneʁ^{w}ə-xe-m a-dež'] arə [$_{RC}$ Op$_i$ t_i(LOC)
1SG.PP-POSS-neighbor-PL-OBL 3PL.PP-at PRED
sə- **z-** še- ʒeg^{w}ə -re -r [$_{CP}$ mə pŝaŝe-r *pro*$_i$/*___$_{PG}$(LOC)
1SG.ABS- **WH.IO-** LOC- play -DYN -ABS this girl-ABS
Ø- **Ø/*zə-** š'- e- čəje -fe]]
3ABS- 3SG/***WH.IO-** LOC- DYN- sleep -LIM
'At our neighbors' is where I play while this girl sleeps there.'

- A relativized DP that is cross-referenced with a locative applicative prefix can license a parasitic gap.

(30)

[$_{RC}$ Op$_i$ λepqə-r [$_{CP}$ ___$_{PG}$(LOC) Ø- **zə-** š'ə- rehatə -ʁe -w] t_i(LOC)
tribe-ABS 3ABS- **WH.IO-** LOC- settle -PST -ADV
Ø- **zə-** š'ə- beʁ^{w}a -ʁe] -r a wəne-çəḳ^{w}ə-xe-r arə
3ABS- **WH.IO-** LOC- reproduce -PST -ABS that house-small-PL-ABS PRED
'Those small houses are where the tribe multiplied, having settled there.'
(http://adyghe.web-corpora.net/index_en.html)

4 The analysis: High absolutive syntax

4.1. The Absolutive Constraint

- **Absolutive Constraint on Parasitic Gaps: "**An absolutive trace cannot license a parasitic gap in a clause mate DP."

- An ABS agent (EA) cannot license a parasitic gap in an OBL applied object.

(31)

se sə-Ø-š'e-š'əne [$_{RC}$ ha-w$_i$ t_i(ABS) [$_{DP}$ *pro*$_i$/*___$_{PG}$(PR)
I 1SG.ABS-3SG.IO-LOC-fear dog-ADV
Ø/*z-jə-x^{w}ezjajən](IO) Ø- Ø- je- ceqe -ž'ə -ʁe] -m
3SG/*WH.PR-POSS-owner WH.ABS- 3SG.IO- DAT- bite -RE -PST -OBL
'I fear the dog that bit its owner.'

- An ABS theme (IA) cannot license a parasitic gap in an OBL applied object.

(32)

marə [$_{RC}$ pŝaŝ-ew$_i$ t_i(ABS) [$_{DP}$ *pro*$_i$/*___$_{PG}$(PR) Ø/*z-jane](IO)
here girl-ADV 3SG/*WH.PR-mother
Ø- qə- Ø- fe- s- š'a -ʁe] -r
WH.ABS- DIR- 3SG.IO- BEN- 1SG.ERG- bring -PST -ABS
'Here is the girl whom I brought for her mother.'

- An ABS IA cannot license a parasitic gap in an ERG agent.

(33)

[$_{RC}$ Op$_i$ t_i(ABS) [$_{DP}$ *pro*$_i$/*___$_{PG}$(PR) Ø/*z-jane](ERG)
3SG/*WH.PR-mother
Ø- mə- ʁa- šxe -re] haž^{w}əš'ər-xe-m sə-g^w Ø-a-fe-wəzə
WH.ABS- NEG- CAUS- eat -DYN puppy-PL-OBL 1SG.PR-heart 3ABS-3PL.IO-BEN-ache
'My heart aches for the puppies whom their mother doesn't feed.'

- An ABS IA cannot license a parasitic gap in an OBL experiencer.

(34)

[$_{RC}$ pŝeŝeẑəj-ew$_i$ t_i(ABS) [$_{DP}$ *pro*$_i$/*___$_{PG}$(PR) Ø/*z-jane](IO)
girl-ADV 3SG/*WH.PR-mother
Ø- Ø- š'ə- ʁ^{w}əpša -ʁe] -m sə-g^w Ø-j-e-ʁ^w
WH.ABS- 3SG.IO- LOC- forget -PST -OBL 1SG.PR-heart 3ABS-3SG.ERG-DYN-chew
'I pity the girl whom her mother forgot.' (Lit. 'The girl whom her mother forgot chews my heart.')

The implications of the *Absolute Constraint*, along with the *Anti-C-Command Condition*:

- The absolutive DP c-commands its clausemate DP and the potential site of the parasitic gap → cannot license the parasitic gap.
- It must occupy a specific position that affects other verbal arguments within the clause, regardless of whether it is an external or internal ABS argument.
- This c-commanding position is derived: Spec,TP

(35) [$_{CP}$ Op$_i$ [$_{TP}$ t_i(ABS) [$_{vP}$ [$_{DP(ERG)}$ *___$_{PG}$] [$_{ApplP}$ [$_{DP(IO)}$ *___$_{PG}$] . . .]]]]

- An ERG or IO trace can license parasitic gaps in ABS.

(36) Absolutive theme

a. ERG trace

marə [$_{RC}$ četəw-ew$_i$ [$_{DP}$ *pro*$_i$/___$_{PG}$(PR) Ø/z-jə-šxən](ABS) t_i(ERG)
here cat-ADV 3SG/WH.PR-POSS-food
Ø- zə- mə- šxə -re] -r
3ABS- WH.ERG- NEG- eat -DYN -ABS
'Here is the cat that doesn't eat its food.'

b. IO trace

[$_{RC}$ pŝaŝ-ew$_i$ [$_{DP}$ *pro*$_i$/___$_{PG}$(PR) Ø/z-jə-txəλ](ABS) t_i(IO)
girl-ADV 3SG/WH.PR-POSS-book
Ø- z- e- sə- mə- tə -ž'ə -ʁe] -r Ø-qe-s-e-wəha
3ABS- 3SG.IO- DAT- 1SG.ERG- NEG- give -RE -PST -ABS 3ABS-DIR-1SG.ERG-DYN-avoid
'I avoid the girl to whom I haven't given back her book.'

c. Applied external argument (IO) trace

ṣ^{w}ə Ø-s-λeʁ^{w}ə-r-ep [$_{RC}$ Op$_i$ [$_{DP}$ *pro*$_i$/___$_{PG}$(PR)
good 3ABS-1SG.ERG-see-DYN-NEG
Ø/z-jə-š'ər-xe-r](ABS) t_i(IO) Ø- zə- š'ə- ʁ^{w}əpša -ʁe] četəwə-r
3SG/WH.PR-POSS-cub-PL-ABS 3ABS- WH.IO- LOC- forget -PST cat-ABS
'I don't like the cat that forgot its kittens.'

(37) Absolutive external argument

marə [$_{RC}$ č'ele-çəḳ^w-ew$_i$ [$_{DP}$ *pro*$_i$/___$_{PG}$(PR) Ø/z-jane](ABS) t_i(IO)
here boy-small-ADV 3SG/WH.PR-mother
Ø- zə- fe- g^{w}əbž -zepətə -re] -r
3ABS- WH.IO- BEN- be.angry -always -DYN -ABS
'Here is the boy at whom his mother is always angry.'

4.2. Nonabsolutive DPs and A-scrambling

If we assume that the ergative DP (merged to Spec,vP) c-commands the applied object (merged to Spec,ApplP under vP), then in the correspoding RC structure, this ergative trace must fail to license a parasitic gap within the applied object (in fact, this is not the case), but not vice versa.

(38) An IO trace licensing a parasitic gap in ERG DP

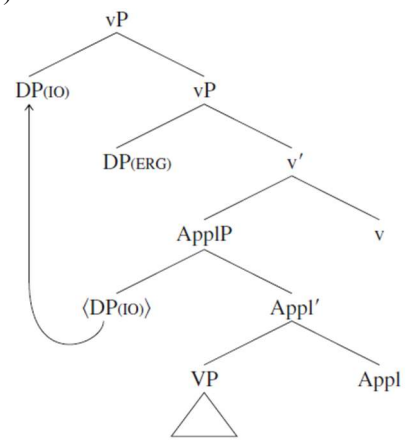
marə [$_{RC}$ č̣'al-ew$_i$ [$_{DP}$ *pro*$_i$/___$_{PG}$(PR) ə/**zə**-š](ERG) t_i(IO) velosjəped
here boy-ADV 3SG/**WH.PR**-brother bicycle
Ø- qə- **ze**- r- jə- tə -ʁe] -r
3ABS- DIR- **WH.IO**- DAT- 3SG.ERG- give -PST -ABS
'Here is the boy$_i$ to whom his$_i$ brother gave a bicycle.'

The applied object may undergo optional A-scrambling to Spec,vP and c-command the ergative agent → an ergative trace can license a parasitic gap within the applied object.

(39)

marə [$_{RC}$ č̣'al-ew$_i$ t_i(ERG) [$_{DP}$ *pro*$_i$/___$_{PG}$(PR) ə/**zə**-š](IO) velosjəped
here boy-ADV 3SG/**WH.PR**-brother bicycle
Ø- Ø- je- **zə**- tə -ʁe] -r
3ABS- 3SG.IO- DAT- **WH.ERG**- give -PST -ABS
'Here is the boy who$_i$ gave a bicycle to his$_i$ brother.'

(40)



The absence of Anti-C-Command Condition effects: Nonabsolutive DPs, such as the ergative and applied object DPs, do not exhibit the same restrictions as absolutive DPs.

The optional A-scrambling is parallel to similar patterns in Hindi, Persian, Japanese, etc. → a syntactic phenomenon across different languages.

4.3. An alternative analysis

Caponigro and Polinsky (2011) advocate for a different mechanism that treats the construction involving a possessor pronoun as a case of Φ-agreement between a *wh*-trace and a bound pronoun.

The relativized ergative participant raises to a specific syntactic position (Spec,TP, in their analysis) and binds a possessor pronoun within an applied object DP. The *wh*-feature is then transferred from the *wh*-trace to the bound pronoun via Φ-agreement.

The Absolutive Constraint is then treated as a ban on Weak Crossover configurations.

Challenges to this analysis:

i. Unnecessary complexity of agreement mechanisms
ii. Failure to capture the optionality of multiple *wh*-agreement constructions
iii. Inconsistent data left unaccounted for
iv. False predictions w.r.t. the Weak Crossover configurations

5 References

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